Project Guidelines 2026-27 (spring start)

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1. Overview

The spring start Masters programme dissertations (going forward, referred to as the "project") are a spring-summer project activity that involves a substantial piece of individual work. It is supervised by one or several members of staff in the CSIS department. This document details the overall process and the submissions you will make. It is assumed that all students have read and understood these guidelines by the end of Week 1 of the Spring Semester. With the submission of your project details form (see Brightspace) you will also sign that you have read and understood these guidelines. In the event of queries, please contact Mr Gavin Wade (gavin.wade@ul.ie , room CS2-006).

2. Finding a project and registering the project details

2.1. It is the responsibility of each student to engage with the steps for identifying a project supervisor and proposal as outlined in the "Identifying Topic and Supervisor" section on Brightspace.

2.2. Students must formally submit their project details form by 12:00 midday, Friday, Week 2 of the Spring Semester, at the latest, fully signed by their supervisor and themselves, including all declarations.

2.3. If the fully signed project details form is not submitted by the deadline of Friday, Week 2 of the Spring Semester, the assumption is that you are not undertaking the project this year and you will fail the project module aspect of your Masters programme. The exception is if you have contacted the coordinator, as outlined on Brightspace.

3. Attendance and continuous work

3.1. Supervisees must arrange regular project meetings with their supervisors, using the supervisor's preferred mechanism (in-person, Teams, etc.), at a schedule agreed upon with their supervisor. (Note, options for meetings might be more limited in the summer, as supervisors also need to take leave. Ensure you plan well in advance.).

3.2. Supervisees are expected to attend any scheduled meetings and to have fully prepared for them. Failure to attend scheduled meetings will likely have wider implications for the quality of the project and, by extension, grades achievable.

3.3. Students are expected to attend any scheduled sessions given by the project module coordinator, guest speakers, or applicable course director, provided in person of virtually if appropriate to the activity. They also must pay regular attention to announcements made on Brightspace and the material provided there. It is generally assumed that students have taken note of any material discussed during sessions, made in announcements or provided via Brightspace.

4. Assessment Overview

4.1. The project spans the spring and summer semesters, with the bulk of your engagement during the summer period. There is a single grade towards the end of the summer period. Depending upon the course (or as required by an individual assessor) there may be an additional requirement to pass a Dissertation Defence (Presentation) activity to validate the submitted dissertation materials; this would be indicated via Brightspace (for course requirements) or email (as required by an individual assessor).
The grading and deliverables are broken down as follows:

Submission	% of overall project grade	Comments

Friday Week 10 Spring Semester – Literature Review	0	Project introduction and Literature Review submitted for feedback. While this element is not directly graded, the activity, feedback and/or non-submission could impact the final overall grade for this module. This element will have no late penalty applied.
Final submission	100	The final project submission consists of multiple elements. They may include (depending on course): Product (submitted to link provided by Course Director or coordinator) Report (submitted to Brightspace) Showcase video (submitted to Brightspace) Course specific materials in preparation for an exhibition (as applicable, submitted to Course Director, see Brightspace).
Dissertation Defence (Presentation) (as required)	Pass or Fail applied to Report and/or Product Elements	Following the Final submission, you may be required to engage in a 'Dissertation Defence' presentation activity to validate the materials previously submitted for assessment. This may be required on a course basis or may be requested by anyone involved in assessing and grading your work. Failing a Dissertation Defence (Presentation) would invalidate related aspects of the submitted Final submission material, which could be regraded at zero.

4.2. All assessment components are mandatory. The normal (medical or otherwise) certification must be presented to the coordinator if a student is to miss/has missed any submission or requires an extension. Late submissions without such certification are associated with penalties or may result in the submission not being graded at all. Details on late submission penalties are outlined in section 9.

4.3. All submissions, including any repeat or delayed submissions, must be made to the location specified by the coordinator. This is usually a Brightspace link but may vary by course. Students must pay attention to announcements/posts made on Brightspace for details on where to submit different elements of their project. While students may choose to send their submissions to their supervisor separately, these do not count as official submissions. A late penalty will be incurred if submissions to the location specified by the coordinator are late. **Under no circumstances will a submission made to the supervisor only without submission to the location specified by the coordinator be considered a valid submission.**

4.4. Both supervisor and second reader submit a numerical grade for the final project submission. If the second reader's grade falls within +/- 5 marks of that of the supervisor, the supervisor's grade stands. Should the grades submitted by the supervisor fall outside marks submitted by the second reader +/- 5, the outcome may be resolved through mutual agreement, where agreement is not possible an independent adjudicator will be appointed. A second reader will be appointed for the final submission, and where applicable would also engage with the Dissertation Defence (Presentation) activity (if required). Ideally, the second reader will remain the same throughout, but might change depending on the circumstances.

5. Assessment detail: Literature Review submission/report

5.1. Students are required to submit an interim Literature Review report to Brightspace by Friday of Week 10 of the Spring semester. (Some courses may allow a slightly later submission, please check your specific course requirements via Brightspace).

5.2. The report should include the following chapters.

Introduction

- A clear project statement must identify the target problem, issue, opportunity, or design goal.

- A project may be argumentative, analytic, or narrative. Summarise the appropriate methodology or approach that will be taken.
- Provide a short justification for the project in the context of prior practice and research.
- Detail the goals and deliverables.

Background / Literature Review

- Survey prior work in the field by performing a detailed analysis of specific sources.
- Prior work can include academic research, applications, code libraries, designs, or artistic outputs (compositions, films) as relevant to the project.
- Synthesise this information in order to identify key findings relevant to the current project.

Methodology

- Demonstrate how the objectives will be reached.
- Include a timeline and constraints.
- Itemise project requirements and resourcing.
- Consider practical and ethical issues.
- Identify potential points of failure and what is being done to mitigate these.

Conclusions

- Summarise the work done so far relative to the timetable and goals.
- Highlight any new problems or constraints that were not anticipated.
- Note that this section can be brief in this interim report but will be expanded later.

Appendices

- Include any additional material required to evaluate progress on the project.
- Examples: screen shots, photographs, wireframe diagrams, illustrations, code listings, and experimental results.

Overall, the report should provide evidence of sufficient work done to date, and demonstrate organisation and presentation skills, while being correctly written and referenced.

5.3. Other deliverables may be included at the supervisor's discretion, agreed in advance. In particular, the material in the appendices might be better presented in their original form, as models, code libraries, demonstration applications, etc.

5.4. The interim submission will be reviewed using relevant elements of the rubric used for the final project submission, as apply to the elements submitted in the report. While this submission does not contribute to the final grade outcome for the module, a supervisor may wish to (optionally) provide an indicative grade along with their required feedback.

5.5. The supervisor will provide feedback on interim reports submitted by the submission date to the students. Feedback will usually be provided to students within 3 weeks of the submission deadline. Please contact your supervisor to confirm details of the feedback for the interim report.

6. Assessment details: Final submission

6.1. Students are required to submit their final report to Brightspace, and the final product to the upload link provided by the coordinator or where relevant Course Director (see course specific information on Brightspace).

6.2. All projects must include a submission to the product upload link, regardless of the nature of the project. Students should discuss the exact product submission with their supervisor. In the event that there is no product or data that can be submitted, a text-based document stating this must be submitted instead. Failure to do so will mean that the project is only partially submitted, and the delay will get penalised.

6.3. The exact details of the final submission will be discussed with the supervisor and will depend on the nature of the project overall. The final submission will be graded based on a grading rubric, which will be made available to students ahead of time.

6.4. Students are required to use the provided template for the report. They must include and complete all declarations that are included in the template. Failure to do so will result in the submission being rejected, and the student will be required to re-submit, with penalty, prior to the final submission date if such has not been reached.

7. Assessment detail: Dissertation Defence (Presentation)

7.1 As a universal requirement for a course or at the request of an assessor reviewing the submitted work, students may be required to engage in a Dissertation Defence (Presentation) activity relating to their project submission.

7.2 Where a Dissertation Defence (Presentation) is required at course level, the Course Director will make the arrangements and inform participants of the schedule for the activity. Where a Dissertation Defence (Presentation) is at the request of a supervisor, 2nd reader or 3rd marker, they will schedule the activity for the student (ensuring the coordinator is aware of the request and outcome of the activity). Students are required to make themselves available to engage in the presentation activity; non-engagement will result in a Fail outcome invalidating (zero grading) aspects of the Final submission. Any Dissertation Defence (Presentation) must take place during scheduled teaching weeks or the Summer Exam Period. The Course Director will inform the coordinator of the outcome of any course level activity in good time to process the resulting grades before the deadline.

7.3. Students will present a review and reflection of their participation and the outcomes from their dissertation project activity. Unless specified otherwise, a presentation will be approximately 10 minutes followed by 5 minutes Q&A.

7.4. Supervisors attending the presentations will provide verbal feedback to each presenting student.

7.5. The aims of the presentation are:

- To present, and justify, aspects of the project.
- To answer questions and justify the approach, as well as the quality and authenticity of work carried out during the project activity.
- To receive constructive feedback to inform future activity.

7.6. Supervisors may request additional aspects to be included in the presentation and communicate this to the student ahead of time.

7.7. When required to engage in a Dissertation Defence (Presentation), the presentation activity and submission of slide deck are mandatory. The normal (medical or otherwise) certification must be presented to the coordinator if a student is to miss/has missed their presentation or submission date.

8. Submission deadlines and late submissions

8.1. The most important deadline dates are outlined in Table 1. Deadlines can NOT be negotiated between supervisor and student.

Table 1: Spring Start CSIS Project Deadlines. These deadlines are confirmed but subject to change.

		Due	**Detail**
Spring Semester	Deadline for Project Details Form	Friday Week 2	

	Submission Deadline for S&E Ethics Committee	Thursday Week 7	This is the last realistic date to submit an ethics application for projects running in the summer.
	Deadline for Literature Review (not graded)	Friday Week 10	Specific Course may allow a later submission, see Brightspace.
Summer Semester	Deadline for submission of dissertation report and artefact		3rd August 2027 16:00
	Cut-off-date (late) dissertation report and/or artefacts		6th August 2027 16:00
	Dissertation Defence (Presentation) Period	Scheduled by either Course Director or an assessor (on demand) during Summer Exam Period or scheduled teaching.	*CD or assessor will indicate and schedule if Defence is required.* ***Student must make themselves available during Summer Exam Period.***

8.2. The penalties for late submissions are outlined in Table 2:

Table 2: Late submission penalties. Only undergraduate students are required to participate in Showcase Day.

		Penalty Applied	**Comment**
Spring Semester	Deadline for Project Details Form	No Grade (NG)	Students failing to submit the Project Details Form will receive No Grade (NG) for this module.
	Deadline for Literature Review.	None, but see comment	Not graded, but feedback can impact overall grade.
Summer Semester	Final submission date for Report	1% per weekday late	Up to 3 weekdays, no grading after.
	Final submission date for Product	1% per weekday late	Up to 3 weekdays, no grading after.
	Cut-off-date Product & Report	6th August 2027	No grading after this date.

8.3. Supervisor marking will assume 100%, and the penalties will be applied retrospectively by the coordinator.

9. Exceptions and Extensions for Late Submission

9.1. An extension requested by a student can only be granted with the agreement of their supervisor, and the coordinator. In cases where roles are combined (such as in a supervisor who is also the coordinator), the additional agreement of the Head of Department must be sought.
Students should be aware that any arrangement made between the supervisor and the student alone is not valid and consequently any penalties incurred by a delay will be applied.

9.2. Students who require an extension should first get the agreement of their supervisor and should then send an email requesting the extension to the coordinator. The email should give the name of the student, the name of the supervisor, the title of the project, and should specify the reason the extension is required as well as the new deadline date requested. The supervisor should be copied.

9.3. On receipt of the student email, the coordinator will seek the agreement of the appropriate parties.

9.4. If all the parties agree to the request, then the coordinator, in consultation with the supervisor and course leader, will decide on the length of the extension.

9.5. The coordinator will inform the supervisor and the student of the result of the request (including the new deadline if the request is granted) by email. The result of the request will be recorded in the marking sheet by the coordinator and made available to the external examiner.

9.6. All extensions must be agreed before the final submission date. Extensions agreed after the final submission date will incur the appropriate penalty up to the date the extension is agreed. Exceptional circumstances, such as illness, accident, bereavement, or where the student is incommunicado with justification, will be taken into account.

9.7. Failure to submit the project details form by the cut-off-date will automatically result in the student being awarded an NG. Exceptional circumstances, such as illness, accident, bereavement, or where the student is incommunicado with justification, will be taken into account.

9.8. Extensions with no penalty attached will be granted for minor and major illness, personal or family problems, bereavement. Depending on the reason for the request, evidence, in the form of official documentation from the Student Health Centre, Counselling or Chaplaincy services, will be required. The documentation should be provided to the coordinator.

9.9. Failure to submit a project by the cut-off-date will automatically result in the student being awarded an NG. It is the student's responsibility to turn this into an I grade, if appropriate, and should be applied for through Student Services.

10. Repeating Projects

10.1. Students who either fail to submit their project or fail their project may be allowed to repeat, if feasible or link-in to the project module during the following year. This will typically result in delayed graduation.

10.2. Before accepting a proposal from link-in students the coordinator will require evidence that the student has registered for the project module.

10.3. If a student fails to submit or fails their project, the grade will be capped at a C3 in repeats, unless the student has applied and been approved for an I-grade.

11. Intellectual Property Rights (IPR) and Confidentiality

11.1. If relevant, students and supervisors should discuss IPR when proposals are being considered for acceptance. This is especially important when external companies/entities are involved in the project.

11.2. Unless otherwise agreed or stated (such as in license agreements for software used in the project or similar scenarios) the IPR for the products is vested in the student but the IPR for the idea (if thought up by an academic in their role as a university employee) resides with the University.

11.3. As the project needs to be assessed by multiple parties (supervisor, second reader, potential adjudicator, external examiner) and all assessment submissions are archived, it is not possible to enter a non-disclosure agreement for the purpose of undertaking the project. In the event of doubts or potential edge-cases, students

must engage with their supervisor and the coordinator prior to agreeing to any confidentiality or non-disclosure clauses. Failure to do so might result in it not being possible to examine the project and by extension grade it.

12. Research Ethics

12. 1. The University mandates that where research for a project involves human participants, students must apply for ethical approval. This is done by either filling in the application form for module-wide ethics approval, or by completing, and submitting, the appropriate application form directly to the S&E Ethics Committee. Which approach is used depends on the nature of the research.

12. 2. The student and supervisor, in consultation, should complete, and submit, whichever ethics approval form is required.

12. 3. It is the student's responsibility to initiate the application process. It is the supervisor's responsibility to guide the research ethics application process.

12.4. The student must make any data that requires archiving as per the ethics committee requirements available to the supervisor. The supervisor will then ensure that this data is archived or request the archiving from the coordinator.

12.5. Failure to get ethical approval prior to start of data collection for relevant projects, will result in the part of the project that would have needed approval to not be considered for grading. This will likely result in an F grade, or a lower overall mark.

13. Cost of the project

13. 1. The department will aim to support the process by making available resources needed for the project, as far as feasible. These resources might be either loans of hardware/software, or financial reimbursement for limited expenses. Requests for resources must be made and actionable during the Spring Semester (arrangements confirmed prior to the conclusion of teaching in Week 12); it will not be possible for the coordinator to process requests made during the Summer.

13. 2. All reimbursement of expenses must be pre-approved by the department. using the following process:

- The student will discuss and agree the planned expenses with the supervisor.
- If the supervisor agrees that the project is either not possible without these expenses being incurred or that doing so would have a substantial impact on the process, the student will email the coordinator, copying the supervisor, with a detailed break-down of anticipated cost and justification.
- The coordinator will seek approval of the cost from the Head of Department.
- If the cost is approved, the coordinator will inform the student and supervisor. Under normal circumstances, the student will be asked to front the purchase and will be reimbursed after submitting proof of the expense. This would generally be an official invoice/bill with proof of payment. Students should expect the reimbursement process to have a significant lead time, of at least several weeks.
- Students may be required to make the resource approved for reimbursement available to other students, insofar as this is feasible.

14. Academic Integrity and Plagiarism, use of AI

14. 1. The university's regulations on academic integrity and plagiarism apply.

14. 2. Students will be expected to include a declaration on academic integrity and plagiarism with their final report submission.

14. 3. The use of generative AI for any part of the project, at any stage of the process is not permitted, with the exception of the following scenarios:

- The express, written, permission of the supervisor is obtained by email and a copy of the email exchange detailing the student's request and the supervisor's response is included in the report. Further, the report must then include a declaration that describes in detail which AI was used, how and for which purpose.
- The use of generative AI is an integral part of the project, and is as such discussed, in full, in the report.

14.4. The use of generative AI beyond the scenarios described in 14.3 will result in the affected elements of the submission not being included for grading. This will likely result in an F grade, and at a minimum a lower mark.

14.5 Any applicable UL regulations in relation to academic integrity, plagiarism, and the use of AI, also apply.